Illustration by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

have sway in as many as 160 assembly seats and 30 Lok Sabha constituencies. They count 38 MLAs, including 34 from the BJP, and nine MPs.

Their frustration goes back to 2022, when Jal Shakti minister Swatantra Dev Singh, seen as a strong candidate for deputy CM, was passed over. Party insiders trace the BJP's 2024 setback in Kurmi-heavy constituencies to that simmering resentment. The idea now seems to be to wangle handsome recompense, by positioning Swatantra Dev for state party chief, besides ministerial posts for caste fellows.

The Lodhs were the next to raise their banner. On August 16, animal husbandry minister Dharampal Singh organised a large gathering in Aonla, Bareilly, to mark the birth anniversary of freedom fighter Avanti Bai Lodhi. The event, also attended by former Madhya Pradesh CM Uma Bharti, went beyond the symbolic. Lodhs, about 3 per cent of UP's population, can influence 70 assembly and 12 Lok Sabha constituencies. They currently have 23 MLAs—19 from the BJP—and three MPs. Dharampal is seen as another contender for state BJP chief.

Taken together, the three acts of separate but collective bargaining around caste amount to a warning to the party. The 2024 Lok Sabha election had already exposed cracks in its Hindutva 'big tent' formula. Like with the Kurmis, the BJP's losses in Thakur-dominated constituencies were interpreted as evidence of discontent. Their public recourse to open pressure tactics may be infectious. The Brahmins are also restless—they were anyway chafing from signs of Thakur dominance—and they are planning their own show of strength. The central leadership is caught in a bind. Too much appeasement of one caste could spark counter-mobilisation by others. Too little could risk alienating groups that have delivered seats.

"What we are seeing is the 'classisation' of caste," says political scientist Hilal Ahmad of the Centre for the Study of Developing Societies (CSDS). Caste mobilisation is no longer merely about old-fashioned identity politics in his view; rather, communities are now to be "defined also by their material existence and bargaining power". It is up to Hindutva, then, to negotiate this new salience of caste-based bargaining, legitimised by the caste census. ■

Takeaways

- **The leaders of three big caste blocs within UP BJP meet to up their demands**
- **The Thakurs, influential in 90-odd assembly and 20 LS seats, demand new berths**
- **Kurmis, too, don't see a share matching their 160/30 seat footprint; seek a Dy CM**
- **Lodhs, eyeing state BJP chief's post, follow suit; the Brahmins said to be next**